

Ecclesiastical Latin

EL-I.7: *Sum* and *Possum*

Recognize the six indicative tenses of *sum*, use *possum* with its infinitive, and distinguish predicate complements from objects

Stage	Stage I — Foundations
Prerequisite	EL-I.6 mastery: trace noun–adjective agreement and classify adjective use
Next	EL-I.8, The Present Active System

Read *EL-GUIDE: Start Here* before using this packet. Course method, pacing, source conventions, and answer protocol are stated there; this module begins with its lesson and assumes previously taught terms.

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Part I

Lesson

CHAPTER 1

Unit 7: *Sum* and *Possum*

On completing this unit, you can:

- recognize all indicative forms of *sum* in the present and perfect systems;
- conjugate the corresponding systems of *possum*;
- identify predicate nouns and adjectives; and
- restore a clearly implied form of *sum* in a liturgical clause.

1.1 The indicative of *sum*

The **indicative mood** normally presents an action or state as asserted or asked about, rather than commanded, wished, or treated as contingent. *Sum*, “be”, is a **linking verb** or **copula**: it joins a subject to a predicate complement rather than transferring action to a direct object.

A verb’s **present system** comprises present, imperfect, and future; its **perfect system** comprises perfect, pluperfect, and future perfect. The present and perfect systems use different stems in ordinary verbs. The **subjunctive mood**, previewed here in prayer formulas, can present an action as wished, commanded, possible, or dependent rather than simply asserted; Volume II teaches its complete formation and uses.

	1 sg.	2 sg.	3 sg.	1 pl.	2 pl.	3 pl.
Present	sum	es	est	sumus	estis	sunt
Imperfect	eram	eras	erat	eramus	eratis	erant
Future	ero	eris	erit	erimus	eritis	erunt
Perfect	fui	fuisti	fuit	fuimus	fuistis	fuerunt
Pluperfect	fuera	fueras	fuera	fueramus	fueratis	fuerant
Future perfect	fuiro	fueris	fuerit	fuerimus	fueritis	fuerint

The present infinitive is *esse*, the perfect infinitive *fuisse*, and the imperatives are *es* and *este*. *Sum* links a subject to a nominative predicate noun or adjective; it does not take an accusative object. In prayers, present subjunctives *sit*, “may it be”, and *sint*, “may they be”, often express a wish. For now, recognize those two forms without attempting a complete subjunctive system.

1.2 The compound *possum*

	1 sg.	2 sg.	3 sg.	1 pl.	2 pl.	3 pl.
Present	possum	potes	potest	possumus	potestis	possunt
Imperfect	poteram	poteras	poterat	poteramus	poteratis	poterant
Future	potero	poteris	poterit	poterimus	poteritis	poterunt
Perfect	potui	potuisti	potuit	potuimus	potuistis	potuerunt

Complete the remaining perfect tenses regularly from *potu-*: *potueram*, *potueras*, . . . and *potuero*, *potueris*, The present infinitive is *posse*; the perfect infinitive is *potuisse*. *Possum* normally takes a **complementary infinitive**, an infinitive that completes the meaning of another verb: *possum videre*, “I am able to

see”.

Worked example: *Dignum et iustum est*

Worked passage ID: W.I.25; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

est is third-person singular present. Neuter predicate adjectives *dignum* and *iustum* refer to the action just proposed: “It is fitting and just.”

Worked example: *Non sum dignus ut intres sub tectum meum*

Worked passage ID: W.I.26; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

sum is first-person singular present; predicate *dignus* is masculine singular nominative because the traditional speaker is grammatically masculine. *intres* is second-person singular present active subjunctive in an *ut*-clause completing predicate adjective *dignus*; full subjunctive formation belongs to a later volume. Translation: “I am not worthy that you should enter under my roof.”

Worked example: *Pleni sunt caeli et terra gloria tua*

Worked passage ID: W.I.27; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

sunt is third-person plural present because its compound subject is plural. Predicate *pleni* remains nominative. Translation: “Heaven and earth are full of your glory.”

Worked example: *Ego sum via, et veritas, et vita (Jn 14:6)*

Worked passage ID: W.I.28; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

ego is the nominative subject. The three predicate nouns are also nominative, not accusative. Translation: “I am the way, and the truth, and the life.”

Worked example: *Sine me nihil potestis facere (Jn 15:5)*

Worked passage ID: W.I.29; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

potestis is second-person plural present and takes complementary infinitive *facere*. *nihil* is the accusative object of *facere*: “Without me you can do nothing.”

In *Dominus vobiscum*, a blessing, understand *sit*: “The Lord be with you”. Liturgical Latin often omits a form that the setting makes obvious; bracket the supplied word in a close analysis instead of pretending it is printed.

1.3 Handwritten study and controlled composition

Write the six tenses of *sum* from memory, then cover the table and reproduce each person-column by tense rather than each row by tense. Derive four tenses of *possum* by hand and underline its infinitive complement in five self-written clauses. Change *sum dignus* through all six persons; change it to imperfect and future. Compose “we were ready”, *parati eramus*; “they will be holy”, *sancti erunt*; and “you (plural) can praise God”, *potestis Deum laudare*.

Part II

Practice

CHAPTER 1

Transfer, retrieval, and application

1.1 The indicative of *sum* — transfer practice

Connection. A copula/predicate/complement triage begins with the verb's function rather than an English word order.

Transfer task. For the project-composed clauses *Maria magistra est*, *Discipuli parati erant*, and *Pax erit donum*, box the copula, underline the subject, and double-underline every predicate complement. Then change only the tense.

Retrieval check. State the case of both subject and predicate complement and explain why neither is a direct object.

1.2 The compound *possum* — transfer practice

Connection. The ability verb and its infinitive form one verbal center while retaining distinct finite and non-finite jobs.

Transfer task. For the project-composed clause *Discipulus potest legere*, label person, number, tense, and mood on *potest*; label *legere* as complementary infinitive; then change the subject to plural and the time to past ability.

Retrieval check. Explain which verb anchors the clause and which form supplies the activity made possible.

1.3 Handwritten study and controlled composition — transfer practice

Connection. An independent exit ticket tests whether paradigms support clause analysis instead of remaining isolated recitation.

Transfer task. Without notes: parse *fueraimus*, *erunt*, *potuistis*; supply nominative predicate forms for a plural subject; build one project-composed ability clause; and bracket an omitted copula in a verbless project-composed acclamation.

Retrieval check. Write one sentence distinguishing object, predicate complement, and complementary infinitive.

Part III

Worksheets

CHAPTER 1

Unit 7: *Sum* and *Possum*

Worksheet I.26 — Variant B

Worksheet ID: I.26

Focus: Perfect-system forms and linking-clause syntax**Use:** This is equivalent to Variant A but ranges across all six indicative tenses.

1. Write all six persons of the perfect active indicative of *sum*.

-
2. Parse *fuera*mus, *fuero*, *fu*erint, *fu*it; note any form that can be ambiguous outside this unit's indicative frame.

-
3. Transform *sancti erunt*, “they will be holy”, into imperfect, perfect, and pluperfect.

-
4. Give the present and perfect infinitives and the singular/plural imperatives of *sum*.

-
5. Diagnose *Via et veritas est bonæ*, intended “The way and truth are good”.

-
6. **Text:** *Ego sum via, et veritas, et vita*.

Passage ID: I.26.1; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

Identify subject, linking verb, and all predicate nouns; explain their case and translate.

Worksheet I.27 — Variant C**Worksheet ID:** I.27**Focus:** The compound *possum*, tense contrasts, and ellipsis**Use:** Supply an infinitive wherever ability requires one.

1. Write all six present forms of *possum*.

-
2. Give the requested forms: 3 plural imperfect, 2 singular future, 1 plural perfect, 3 singular pluperfect, 2 plural future perfect of *possum*.

-
3. Translate and distinguish *poterat facere*, *potuit facere*, and *potuerat facere*.

-
4. Complete with the correct form of *possum*:

ego _____ *audire*; nos _____ *laudare*; vos cras _____ *venire*.

-
5. Correct *Possunt Deum laudant*.

-
6. **Text:** *Sine me nihil potestis facere*.

Passage ID: I.27.1; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

Parse *potestis*, identify its infinitive and the roles of *me* and *nihil*, then translate.

Part IV

Assessment

CHAPTER 1

Mastery assessment and record

Advance when: Write at least 34 of 36 displayed *sum* forms correctly, parse at least 18 of 20 *sum/possum* forms, and analyze five linking or ability clauses without confusing predicate, object, or infinitive complement.

Complete the assessment before opening the answer part. Record evidence, not confidence or elapsed time.

Evidence	First attempt	Delayed check
Date and conditions		
Worksheet ID and score		
Mastery task and result		
One recurring error family		
Correction stated as a rule		
Unseen or remediation item used		

If the criterion is met: continue to EL-I.8, The Present Active System.

If it is not met: Worksheets I.25 and I.28 remain optional remediation or delayed-recall variants.

Advance / remediate decision: _____ **Next review date:** _____

Reason in one complete sentence: _____

Part V

Answer Key

Open this part only after completing the assessment record. Use the comparison and alternative-answer protocol in EL-GUIDE.

CHAPTER 1

Practice models and rubrics

The indicative of *sum* — model and rubric

Model / acceptable evidence. In each project-composed clause, the subject and predicate noun or adjective are nominative; *est*, *erant*, and *erit* link rather than transfer action. A tense change alters the copula while preserving the nominal relation unless another coordinate is deliberately changed.

The compound *possum* — model and rubric

Model / acceptable evidence. The transformed clause may be *Discipuli poterant legere*. Finite *potest/poterant* anchors person, number, tense, and mood; *legere* is non-finite and completes the idea of ability.

Handwritten study and controlled composition — model and rubric

Model / acceptable evidence. Expected parses are first-person plural pluperfect of *sum*, third-person plural future of *sum*, and second-person plural perfect of *possum*. Predicate forms must agree with the plural subject; the ability clause needs finite *possum* plus an infinitive; a supplied copula must be visibly bracketed. The final distinction must identify accusative target, nominative completion, and non-finite verbal completion respectively.

CHAPTER 2

Unit 7: *Sum* and *Possum*

Solution I.26 — Variant B

Worksheet ID: I.26

Focus: Perfect-system forms and linking-clause syntax**Use:** This is equivalent to Variant A but ranges across all six indicative tenses.

1. Write all six persons of the perfect active indicative of *sum*.

Answer / model: *fui, fuisti, fuit, fuimus, fuistis, fuerunt*.

2. Parse *fueraamus*, *fuero*, *fuerint*, *fuit*; note any form that can be ambiguous outside this unit's indicative frame.

Answer / model: *fueraamus*: 1 plural pluperfect active indicative; *fuero*: 1 singular future perfect active indicative; *fuerint*: 3 plural future perfect active indicative, also potentially perfect subjunctive; *fuit*: 3 singular perfect active indicative.

3. Transform *sancti erunt*, “they will be holy”, into imperfect, perfect, and pluperfect.

Answer / model: *sancti erant*; *sancti fuerunt*; *sancti fuerant*.

4. Give the present and perfect infinitives and the singular/plural imperatives of *sum*.

Answer / model: Present infinitive *esse*; perfect infinitive *fuisse*; imperatives *es*, *este*.

5. Diagnose *Via et veritas est bonæ*, intended “The way and truth are good”.

Answer / model: *Via et veritas sunt bonæ*. Compound subject requires plural *sunt*; predicate adjective is feminine plural nominative *bonæ*.

6. **Text:** *Ego sum via, et veritas, et vita*.

Passage ID: I.26.1; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

Identify subject, linking verb, and all predicate nouns; explain their case and translate.

Answer / notes: *ego*: nominative subject; *sum*: 1 singular present active indicative; *via*, *veritas*, *vita*: coordinated nominative predicate nouns. “I am the way, and the truth, and the life.”

Solution I.27 — Variant C**Worksheet ID:** I.27**Focus:** The compound *possum*, tense contrasts, and ellipsis**Use:** Supply an infinitive wherever ability requires one.

1. Write all six present forms of *possum*.

Answer / model: *possum, potes, potest, possumus, potestis, possunt.*

2. Give the requested forms: 3 plural imperfect, 2 singular future, 1 plural perfect, 3 singular pluperfect, 2 plural future perfect of *possum*.

Answer / model: *poterant, poteris, potuimus, potuerat, potueritis.*

3. Translate and distinguish *poterat facere*, *potuit facere*, and *potuerat facere*.

Answer / model: “He was able/could do”; “he was able/managed to do”; “he had been able to do”. They are imperfect, perfect, and pluperfect respectively, all with complementary *facere*.

4. Complete with the correct form of *possum*:

ego _____ audire; nos _____ laudare; vos cras _____ venire.

Answer / model: *ego possum audire; nos possumus laudare; vos cras poteritis venire.*

5. Correct *Possunt Deum laudant*.

Answer / model: *Possunt Deum laudare*. A finite form of *possum* takes a complementary infinitive, not another finite present verb.

6. **Text:** *Sine me nihil potestis facere.*

Passage ID: I.27.1; exact source and collation state are recorded in the passage inventory.

Parse *potestis*, identify its infinitive and the roles of *me* and *nihil*, then translate.

Answer / notes: *potestis*: 2 plural present active indicative of *possum*; complement *facere*; *me*: ablative after *sine*; *nihil*: neuter accusative object of *facere*. “Without me you can do nothing.”

Part VI

Scope and Sources

CHAPTER 1

Scope and Qualifications

1.1 Packet boundary

This is module EL-I.7, *Sum and Possum*, in Triptych's print-first Ecclesiastical Latin curriculum. It imports one authoritative lesson, transfer practice for its internal submodules, two selected worksheets, one local mastery assessment, and matching solutions. This packet teaches the indicative of *sum* and operational *possum*; complete subjunctive morphology remains in Stage II.

The unprinted worksheet variants remain course-owned extension material; their omission is intentional and is not a claim that the module exhausts available practice. EL-GUIDE owns the course-wide study method, pacing, lookup discipline, answer protocol, source classes, and advancement rules; this packet assumes that orientation and terminology taught in prerequisite modules.

1.2 Controlling records and local state

Course-wide research records own the edition, passage, answer, curriculum, and source decisions; the leaf's module map records this packet's selection and transfer practice. EL-GUIDE owns the corpus, normalization, translation, non-authority, review, and answer conventions that apply here. Claim-local qualifications remain beside the affected material; check received wording against the course-wide passage inventory.

Any installed snapshot is a working study held from release until its exact bytes and outstanding distribution gates receive separate authorization.

CHAPTER 2

References

The following works are the course's controlling corpus and reference aids. Project-composed explanation, translation, analysis, exercises, and models are distinguished from received wording under the convention stated in the Scope and Qualifications appendix. Short source passages are identified so that the learner can verify their wider context. The adjacent edition manifest and passage inventory record exact source roles, checks, access states, and known rights limits.

2.1 Primary corpus

- Catholic Church, *Missale Romanum ex decreto SS. Concilii Tridentini restitutum, Summorum Pontificum cura recognitum*, editio typica (Rome, 1962). A searchable presentation of the edition is hosted by the Holy See's Biblia Clerus project: <https://www.clerus.org/bibliaclerusonline/EN/gmb.htm>.
- A page-image scan of the 1962 typical edition is available through the Church Music Association of America: <https://media.churchmusicassociation.org/pdf/missale62.pdf>. Page images, rather than unsourced transcriptions, should decide doubtful punctuation or spelling.

- The Clementine Vulgate is the principal biblical comparison corpus. The public-domain 1914 edition edited by Michael Hetzenauer and its provenance are described at <https://www.sacredbible.org/vulgate1914/>.

2.2 Grammar and lexicography

- J. H. Allen and J. B. Greenough, *New Latin Grammar for Schools and Colleges* (1903), a donor-declared public-domain reference whose digital locator was not independently consulted during integration: <https://archive.org/details/allengreenoughsn01alle>.
- Charles E. Bennett, *New Latin Grammar*, 1918 revision, Project Gutenberg eBook 15665; public-domain text in the United States: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/15665>.
- Charlton T. Lewis and Charles Short, *A Latin Dictionary* (1879), searchable transcription: <https://logeion.uchicago.edu/lexidium>.
- Charles du Fresne, sieur du Cange, *Glossarium mediae et infimae latinitatis*, a donor-declared later-vocabulary aid whose digital locator was not independently consulted during integration: <http://ducange.enc.sorbonne.fr/>.

The underlying 1903, 1918, 1879, and 1883–1887 printed works are public domain in the United States. Digital transcriptions and interfaces retain their own terms and are cited as access tools, not relicensed or reproduced wholesale. The 1962 Missal, Scripture, official text, and other received wording retain their own status; see the scope appendix, research records, and final-page rights notice.

Classical reference grammars describe the inherited system but do not by themselves explain every biblical or ecclesiastical development. The advanced volume therefore distinguishes classical baseline, Vulgate usage, later Christian usage, and stable liturgical formula instead of labeling every difference an “exception.”

2.3 Citation convention

Missal passages are cited by liturgical location and text genre rather than by a page number that varies among printings. Biblical texts are cited by book, chapter, and verse. Historical authors are cited by work and section wherever possible. A learner preparing a formal commentary should verify each passage against the edition actually being used and record any variant. These references are not a claim that every historical-linguistic question can be settled by the listed school grammars and dictionary interfaces.

CHAPTER 3

Generation Metadata

Last revised (UTC): 2026-07-21T17:50:56Z

Model: GPT-5-based Codex agent; unexposed: exact model identifier and model qualifiers

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (curriculum architecture, module design, enrichment, source and answer audit, correction, production, and review); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; unexposed: server revision

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (whole-curriculum structure audit, shared typesetting and selection correction, rendered-structure regression checks, production, and review); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; unexposed: server revision

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (whole-curriculum Part-scoped numbering and rendered contents hierarchy correction, rendered contents-geometry regression checking, production, and review); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; unexposed: server revision

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (starter-guide consolidation, module-flow and definition-retrieval revision, stage-boundary assessment correction, catalog and audit records, production, and review); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; unexposed: server revision

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